

In its second year, the *Digit* 'Icons of Trust' attempts to quantify and rate customer service in India from IT product companies and the results are a revelation, to say the least

Team Digit

There is this real-life story about customer care in Rhonda Abrams' groundbreaking management case study book *Wear Clean Underwear: Business Wisdom From Mom*. The story is about a woman who was using a set of car tyres, and later found them to be faulty. She took the set of tyres, and stormed into Nordstrom, a fashion retail chain in the US, demanding a refund. The clerk at Nordstrom could have refused her the refund, saying she never bought the tyres there. Instead, he spoke to the higher-ups, got an approval, and refunded the customer the entire money spent on the tyres.

This may be a small event in the history of a multi-billion dollar company that has over 400 stores. But, it is not about the money they lost that day. It is about a lifelong customer they acquired thanks to their customer-friendly outlook.

Not surprisingly, Nordstrom has been consistently rated as a world leader in customer satisfaction, an aspect of business most often ignored in companies in India and across the world.

Customer satisfaction is a feeling tough to judge. How do you put a figure to a smile on your face? How do you rate an emotion that makes you share your acquisition with others? How do you retain a customer for life, and if he does come back to you again and again, what makes him do so?

With its groundbreaking survey 'Icons of Trust', which it instituted last year, *Digit* has been trying to understand just that. It is a survey of perceptions; perceptions that are based upon experience once the product is bought.

This year, *Digit* polled more than 3,000 users of technology across the country in 14 product categories. In an exercise that went on for more than 45 days, rigorous online as well as telephone polling by Team *Digit* gathered more than 11,000 records.

While some of the results were expected, there were some surprises in store.

The multimedia team managed the online data and *Digit*'s call centre undertook the task of calling up hundreds of readers from its database. What followed was nothing short of a revelation.

Digit's brand head Prashant Narekuli then crunched the data into understandable formulas, and then easy-to-refer-to results. As the complete picture began to emerge, there was an understanding nod whenever an expected company won. And when a dark horse breasted the tape first though there was another's reaction. This time it was: "Wow, but I never imagined buyers trusted this company." Guess what—we had to humbly bow to the reality of the market. It is only real experience that defines perception.

More than anything else, the *Digit* 'Icons of Trust' results have been enlightening. From the survey, IT product organisations in India will figure what makes them good and what makes them mediocre in the customer's mind. And buyers will know what products they can bet their money on.